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The End of Self- Optimization: Social Control Beyond Marcuse and Han

Social control in advanced industrial societies has shifted from overt coercion to increasingly subtle forms of integration. In *One-Dimensional Man* (1964), Herbert Marcuse describes a "comfortable, smooth, reasonable, democratic unfreedom," where technological rationality produces a society that appears free while quietly limiting critique (Marcuse 3). More than fifty years later, Byung-Chul Han extends this diagnosis in *Psychopolitics* (2017), arguing that control no longer relies on repression or discipline but operates through freedom itself. Individuals are not forced into obedience but encouraged to express themselves within systems of visibility and surveillance, internalizing power by reproducing the systems that govern them. This trajectory extends into digital systems of automation and computation.

While both Marcuse and Han remain deeply relevant, the rise of generative AI and autonomous digital systems suggests that their frameworks must be extended further. We are entering a condition of "algorithmic redundancy," in which the human subject is no longer only shaped or optimized by systems, but becomes structurally non-essential within certain operations of decision-making and knowledge production. In these domains, agency is not directly controlled but gradually pre-empted, as automated systems generate, evaluate, and circulate outputs without requiring sustained human initiation or judgment.

Marcuse's critique remains foundational because it shows how technological rationality becomes political rationality. In a one-dimensional society, individuals lose the ability to imagine alternatives beyond what already exists. They "recognize themselves in their commodities," meaning identity becomes tied to consumption and participation in the system (Marcuse 30). Today, this insight still holds, but the nature of "commodities" has shifted. They are no longer only physical goods, but digital platforms and interfaces that structure attention.

These systems function as a kind of "digital habitus," shaping not only what we consume but how we think and interact (Han 62). Control operates not through force, but through familiarity, convenience, and repetition. The system becomes effective precisely because it feels natural.

Han's contribution is to show how this dynamic intensifies under neoliberalism. Unlike earlier disciplinary systems based on rules and prohibitions, contemporary power works through encouragement and self-direction. Individuals become "entrepreneurs of themselves," constantly managing their productivity and self-worth (Han 2).

Social media platforms make this especially visible. Users voluntarily share information, track engagement, and seek validation through metrics like likes and comments. What appears as self-expression is also a form of continuous self-surveillance. The "Like" button functions as a "digital Amen," reinforcing alignment with system logic while maintaining the illusion of autonomy (Han 15). Control becomes efficient not because it is imposed, but because it is reproduced from within.

However, this model begins to break down with the emergence of AI systems. With tools that can generate text, complete tasks, and make predictions autonomously, human participation is no longer always required. Systems increasingly operate through feedback loops where AI generates and evaluates content itself. In some domains, humans are no longer active participants but observers of processes they do not meaningfully direct. This introduces a deeper shift. We are moving toward fully automated loops in which both production and evaluation occur without sustained human involvement. In this context, even Han's "entrepreneur of the self" begins to disappear. The subject is no longer primarily exploited through self-optimization; instead, it risks becoming structurally unnecessary.

What is emerging is not just automation, but a form of preemptive substitution, where systems act before human intention fully forms. AI agents increasingly anticipate, initiate, and complete actions on behalf of users, filtering information, responding to messages, and making decisions. This marks a shift from influencing decisions to replacing the decision itself. The risk is no longer simply that humans are controlled, but that they are displaced from meaningful agency.

From this perspective, Marcuse's warning about reducing human beings to "mere stuff of domination" takes on a new meaning (Marcuse 47). The issue is no longer only control, but translation: human behavior is converted into data structures that can be processed, predicted, and acted upon without remainder.

Sheila Jasanoff's concept of co-production helps explain why this transformation is so difficult to resist. Technologies do not simply shape society from the outside; they actively produce new forms of social order while being shaped by them. This is visible in platforms like ridesharing apps, where algorithms do not just organize labor but redefine what it means to be a worker.

Drivers are tracked, rated, and optimized, while simultaneously sustaining the system that governs them. Technology does not simply manage behavior; it produces new norms of efficiency, value, and identity.

In this environment, the boundaries between knowledge, governance, and economy blur. What counts as valid knowledge is increasingly determined by systems optimized for efficiency rather than reflection. As a result, control operates not only through individuals, but through infrastructures that structure reality itself.

This makes resistance more complex. Marcuse's search for oppositional subjects assumes critique requires a human agent outside the system, while Han's "idiotism" proposes withdrawal from digital connectivity (Han 81). Yet in highly datafied environments, even silence becomes legible and is reabsorbed as data, making refusal less clearly external to power.

As AI systems increasingly operate autonomously without continuous human initiation, the space for simple negation shrinks further. Resistance thus shifts from avoidance to interference, disrupting or misaligning with algorithmic systems in ways that exceed prediction. Ultimately, Marcuse and Han remain relevant because they trace a shared movement in which power becomes less visible, more internalized, and more productive. What changes today is its extension into autonomous infrastructures that can operate with minimal direct human participation.

In conclusion, the shift from Marcuse's "Happy Consciousness" to Han's psychopolitics and now toward algorithmic redundancy marks a deeper transformation in subjectivity itself. Control no longer simply shapes human behavior; it constructs environments in which human agency is optional, anticipated, or bypassed. The challenge today is not only to recognize these systems, but to defend forms of thought and life that cannot be fully predicted or optimized. The most urgent form of resistance may lie in preserving spaces of uncertainty, uselessness, and silence, forms of life that refuse to be absorbed into the algorithm's "amen."

Works Cited

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